ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

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Entrepreneurship for Students: From Idea to First Paying Customer

Validate a business idea cheaply before you spend money on it

MONEY & CAREER

Money & Career

General Studies (GST / CED)
Centre for Entrepreneurship Development (CED) | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Study smarter. Ask better questions. Pass with understanding.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Most student businesses fail because nobody wanted the product, not because the owner lacked passion. This pack teaches problem-first thinking, cheap validation, unit economics and a first-sale plan, with Nigerian campus examples you can test within a week.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Identify a real problem and define a specific customer.
- Validate demand before investing capital.
- Calculate simple unit economics and a break-even point.
- Plan and execute a first sale, then decide whether to continue.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Start from a problem

A business exists to solve a problem someone will pay to remove.

- Define the customer narrowly: '200-level engineering students in hostels' rather than 'students'.
- Describe the problem in their words, not yours.
- Check whether they currently solve it and how much that costs them.
- Avoid ideas that rely on everyone adopting a new habit.
- Look for frequent, painful and urgent problems.
- Write one problem statement before writing a business plan.

Validate cheaply

Do not build first and ask later.

1. Talk to ten real potential customers without pitching.
2. Ask what they do now, what it costs and what frustrates them.
3. Offer a manual version of the service to three people for a small fee.
4. Record whether they pay, not whether they say it is a good idea.
5. Adjust the offer based on what they actually paid for.
6. Only buy stock or build a product after evidence of willingness to pay.

> **Compliments are not demand**
> 'That is a nice idea' costs nothing. Payment, a deposit or a pre-order is evidence.

Unit economics and the first sale

A business that loses money on every sale cannot grow out of the problem.

- Price minus variable cost equals contribution per unit.
- Calculate break-even: fixed costs divided by contribution per unit.
- Count your own time as a cost, even if you do not pay yourself yet.
- Start with a narrow offer and deliver it excellently.
- Collect feedback and one testimonial from the first customer.
- Decide honestly after 30 days: continue, adjust or stop.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Why define a narrow customer segment?

Answer: Narrow segments make it easier to find customers, understand their problems and tailor an offer that they will actually pay for.

2. What is the difference between validation and asking for opinions?

Answer: Validation measures actual behaviour such as payment or pre-order; opinions are cheap and often polite.

3. Contribution per unit is 400 and fixed costs are 8,000. Find break-even.

Answer: 8,000 divided by 400 equals 20 units.

4. Why should you not buy stock before validating?

Answer: Unsold stock ties up capital and turns an unproven idea into a loss.

5. What should you do after the first sale?

Answer: Deliver well, collect feedback and a testimonial, and use the evidence to decide whether to continue, adjust or stop.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write one problem statement in your customer's words.
- [ ] Interview ten potential customers without pitching.
- [ ] Calculate the variable cost of your offer.
- [ ] Set a price and calculate break-even.
- [ ] Run a manual version of the service for three customers.
- [ ] Collect one testimonial.
- [ ] Review results after 30 days and make a decision.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date: